Where is the best instant ramen manufactured:

A data driven comparison between countries and their product using public ramen reviews

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Introduction

Instant noodles are a staple household product that can be found in dozens of countries, and the style, taste and quality can differ a lot between producers.

Instant ramen was invented in Japan in 1958 [1], and consumers and importers have often assumed that specific countries, such as Japan, produce the "best" instant ramen. A single average rating cannot settle this, because an average based on few reviews is uncertain. In this report we test the assumption with public review data and ask: **Which country produces the best-rated instant ramen, and is the top country's lead statistically meaningful?**

Data sample

We use the *Ramen Ratings* dataset published on Kaggle [2], which is based on reviews by *The Ramen Rater* [3]. It contains 2,580 reviews, each of them reviewing a single instant-noodle product. The columns relevant to this analysis are:

- `Country`: country of manufacture (38 raw labels);
- `Stars`: rating from 0 to 5, mostly in steps of 0.25;
- `Brand`, `Variety`, `Style`: product information (355 brands; mostly packs, bowls and cups).

Three reviews marked `Unrated` were removed, which left us with 2,577 rated products. Country names were standardised: *Holland*→Netherlands, *Dubai*→United Arab Emirates, *United States*→USA, and *Sarawak* (a Malaysian state)→Malaysia. After this step we were left with 35 distinct countries.

Analysis method

The analysis was written in base R and developed in VS Code. For each country c with n_c reviews we computed the mean rating $\bar{x}_c$, the standard deviation s_c and the standard error of the mean $\sigma_c = s_c/\sqrt{n_c}$. A mean based on only a few reviews is unreliable, so only countries with $n_c \geq 10$ were kept (21 of 35 countries, which covered a total of 2,514 reviews). These countries were then ranked by $\bar{x}_c$. To decide whether two countries really differ, we treated their means as independent and computed

$$\Delta = \bar{x}_1 - \bar{x}_2, \qquad \sigma_\Delta = \sqrt{\sigma_1^2 + \sigma_2^2}. \tag{1}$$

We call a difference significant if $\Delta > 2\sigma_\Delta$ (roughly a 95% confidence level).

Results and discussion

The average rating over all products is 3.65 ± 0.02 stars. Figure 1 shows the ten best-rated countries. Of the 21 countries that pass the cutoff, the USA ranks 12th (3.46 ± 0.06) and Canada is last (2.24 ± 0.20).

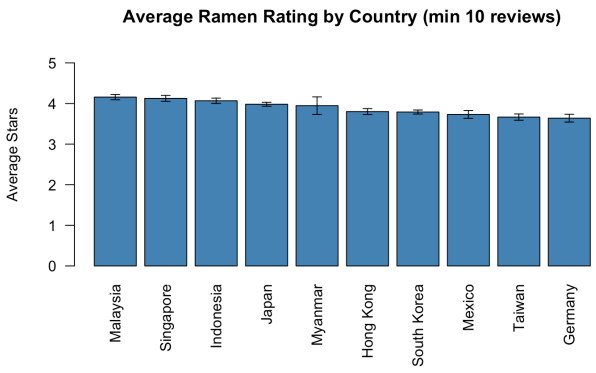


Figure 1: Mean star rating of the ten best-rated countries (at least 10 reviews each). Error bars show ±1 standard error of the mean.

Malaysia has the highest mean rating, followed closely by Singapore:

$$\bar{x}_{\text{Malaysia}} = 4.16 \pm 0.06, \qquad \bar{x}_{\text{Singapore}} = 4.13 \pm 0.07, \qquad \Delta = 0.03 \pm 0.10.$$

The difference is only about $0.3\,\sigma_\Delta$, far below the $2\sigma_\Delta$ threshold. **We therefore cannot say that Malaysian ramen is better than Singaporean ramen: the two are statistically tied for first place**, and Indonesia (4.07 ± 0.07) is close behind. The top three are all Southeast Asian countries. Japan, the country with the most reviews, comes fourth (3.98 ± 0.05). Its gap to Malaysia is $\Delta = 0.18 \pm 0.08$, or $2.2\,\sigma_\Delta$, which is just above our threshold. So the data do not support the assumption that Japan produces the best-rated ramen. Myanmar, fifth (3.95 ± 0.22), has the largest error bar in Figure 1: its mean rests on only 14 reviews, all of products from a single brand, with ratings spread from 2.75 to 5 stars. Its mean is therefore poorly determined and consistent with Malaysia's ($\Delta = 0.21 \pm 0.23$, or $0.9\,\sigma_\Delta$).

In contrast, the spread across the whole ranking is large. With the same method, the gap between Malaysia and the lowest-ranked country, Canada, is $\Delta = 1.91 \pm 0.21$ stars, a difference of about $9\,\sigma_\Delta$. So the country of origin clearly affects the rating, even though the best countries cannot be separated from each other.

Figure 2 shows the mean rating of every country against its number of reviews, and it explains why the cutoff is needed. Without the cutoff, Brazil (4.35 stars from only 5 reviews) would rank first and Nigeria (1.5 stars from a single review) last. Countries with many reviews lie closer to the overall mean, yet Malaysia, Singapore and Indonesia remain about 0.5 stars above it with more than 100 reviews each. So their lead is not a small-sample effect.

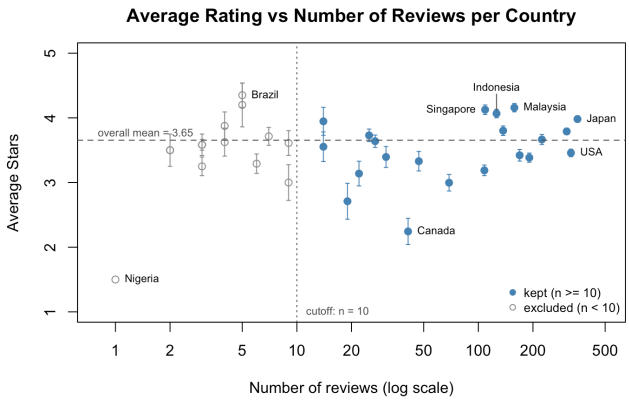


Figure 2: Mean star rating against number of reviews for all 35 countries (log scale). Filled points pass the 10-review cutoff and open points are excluded. The dashed line is the overall mean. Error bars show ± 1 standard error.

Conclusion

The best-rated instant ramen comes from Malaysia (4.16 ± 0.06 stars), Singapore and Indonesia, about 0.5 stars above the overall average. Malaysia's lead over Singapore (0.03 ± 0.10 stars) is not statistically meaningful, so there is no single best country. The country of origin does matter, however: Malaysia is above Japan by $2.2\,\sigma_\Delta$ and above Canada by $9\,\sigma_\Delta$. There are two limitations. All ratings come from a single reviewer and the products were not sampled at random, which the standard errors do not account for. And because we compare several pairs of countries, a $2.2\,\sigma_\Delta$ result such as the Japan gap is only weak evidence.

References

[1] CUPNOODLES MUSEUM OSAKA IKEDA, *About*, n.d. `https://www.cupnoodles-museum.jp/en/osaka_ikeda/about/`

[2] A. Bilogur, *Ramen Ratings*, Kaggle. `https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/residentmario/ramen-ratings`

[3] H. Lienesch, *The Ramen Rater: The Big List*. `https://www.theramenrater.com`